

Why Paul Preached Without Charge

A close reading of 1 Corinthians 9:1–23 · Companion to Digital Study 58

Paul’s statement that a “dispensation” was entrusted to him appears in the middle of an argument about his conduct at Corinth. He is defending his freedom as an apostle while explaining why he has declined a form of support to which he is entitled. Reading the whole chapter keeps his stewardship from becoming an abstract label detached from the responsibility he actually describes.

A right Paul establishes before declining it · 1 Corinthians 9:1-14

Paul begins with questions about his apostleship and the Corinthians’ knowledge of his work among them (vv. 1–2). He then asks whether he and Barnabas have the right to food and drink and the right to refrain from other work (vv. 3–6). His examples move from ordinary labor to the law’s provision for the working ox and to those who serve at the altar (vv. 7–13). The argument reaches an explicit conclusion in verse 14: those who proclaim the gospel may receive their living from that work.

This sequence matters. Paul does not refuse support because gospel workers have no right to it. He spends much of the chapter establishing the right before saying that he has not used it. His refusal is a deliberate exercise of freedom in Corinth, not a denial of the legitimacy of support.

The obstacle Paul wants to avoid · 1 Corinthians 9:12, 15

In verses 12 and 15, Paul explains that he has chosen not to use this right. Verse 12 gives his stated concern: he does not want to place an obstacle in the way of the gospel of Christ. His concern governs the choice. It would reverse his argument to make the choice itself a command that every minister must follow in every setting.

Paul’s example also calls for care when applying the passage. Readers may learn from his willingness to surrender a legitimate benefit for the sake of his ministry. They should first recognize both parts of the account: the right is real, and Paul’s decision not to use it is real.

An entrusted task, not a self-appointed achievement • 1 Corinthians 9:16-18

Paul turns in verses 16–18 from the right to support to the necessity of preaching. He cannot boast simply because he proclaims the gospel; a responsibility has been laid upon him. His language about a “dispensation,” or stewardship, in verse 17 belongs to that claim. He understands the task as entrusted to him. He did not appoint himself to it or invent the message.

Verse 18 then returns to the practical question raised by the chapter: how will he exercise his freedom? His answer is to present the gospel without charge and not make full use of his right in the gospel. The commission to preach and the choice about support are closely connected, but they are not identical. The entrusted task explains why Paul must preach; his practice at Corinth shows one way he carries out that task.

Freedom used for the people he serves • 1 Corinthians 9:19-23

Verses 19–23 widen the view. Though free, Paul describes making himself a servant to others for the gospel’s sake. His conduct with different groups serves the aim of reaching them. These verses do not say that the message changes whenever the audience changes. They show Paul adjusting his exercise of freedom as he ministers.

That wider argument helps explain his refusal of support. It belongs to a pattern of willingly limiting a legitimate freedom where using it might hinder his work. The Corinthians can therefore see more than a personal preference about money: they can see how an entrusted responsibility shapes the steward’s decisions.

What this passage establishes

First Corinthians 9 shows a gospel commission that Paul regards as obligatory and an apostolic right that he chooses not to exercise at Corinth. It does not, by itself, define every administration in Scripture or set out a complete timeline of God’s dealings. Nor does Paul’s use of “dispensation” in verse 17 settle the content of the Mystery revealed through him. Those questions require the other passages in which he identifies his stewardship, its recipients, and what was made known.

Continue with Study 58, What Is a Dispensation? This note has followed Paul’s argument at Corinth. The study brings 1 Corinthians 9 alongside Ephesians 3, Colossians 1, and Ephesians 1 to ask what “dispensation” means in each setting and how Paul’s entrusted stewardship operated during the Acts Overlap.

[Explore Digital Study 58: What Is a Dispensation?](#)